THE CRAWL: THE CONCOURSE

Complete Player Manual - LOCAL_ALPHA 0.1.1

What you have in front of you is not just a visual prototype anymore. Codex built a complete six-floor tactical roguelite with an authoritative game server, procedural floors, enemies, bosses, character progression, equipment, crafting, environmental interactions, death, multiplayer, saves, and two broad approaches to each boss.

The fundamental idea to keep in your head is this:

> **You are not playing a normal action RPG. You are giving orders to a deterministic tactical simulation.**

Outside danger, the game behaves quickly and lets you explore almost like a normal dungeon crawler. Once enemies or an active threat appear, the game changes into simultaneous tactical planning. You decide what you intend to do. Your teammates decide what they intend to do. Then the server resolves everybody's plans according to the rules.

That distinction explains almost everything you'll see.

1. THE TITLE SCREEN

You should see **THE CRAWL - CONCOURSE // PRIVATE LOCAL ALPHA**.

The left side is **Enter the Concourse**.

Crawler Name

Purely your character's name.

Background

This is not cosmetic.

Your background modifies your starting attributes. Characters begin around a baseline of **2 in each attribute**, and backgrounds redistribute those numbers.

Background therefore influences what your crawler is naturally good at before the more substantial specialization system arrives later.

Select different backgrounds and you'll notice the explanatory text underneath change.

Suit Palette

This determines your visual color.

Initially you have:

Ochre, Moss, Lilac, Slate, Clay, and Linen.

There are also at least two unlockable palettes:

Broadcast Gold for surviving the Concourse, and **Producer Seal** for earning the relevant favor/unlock.

These are metaprogression cosmetics. Winning doesn't secretly make future characters stronger.

Run Seed

Leave it blank and the game generates a seed.

Enter a number and you can reproduce a particular procedural run.

That's useful later if you find an especially interesting dungeon or something strange happens and we want to reproduce it.

Create Private Room

This starts your game.

Even when playing solo, you're technically creating a one-person multiplayer room. The same server-authoritative rules operate whether there is one player or four.

That's a pretty good architectural decision by Codex because there isn't a separate simplified "fake multiplayer" single-player engine.

2. THE OTHER SIDE: JOINING AND RESUMING

The right panel is for multiplayer and saved games.

Room Code

Each room has a six-character code.

Invitation Secret

There's also a secret contained in the invitation link.

The distinction matters. **The room code isn't considered secret. The invitation secret is.**

Join Room

Another player uses the room code and invitation secret to join your active room.

Reconnect / Resume Saved Run

This is more substantial than it sounds.

The browser remembers your session identity. The server separately maintains the authoritative saved run.

If your browser disconnects, the game tries to reconnect automatically. If that doesn't work, this button can reconnect you to an existing room or restore the run after the host has restarted.

Codex also implemented checksummed saves, backups, corruption recovery, and duplicate-action protection. So this isn't merely a button that reloads a JSON file.

You may also see **Restore a host backup**. That's a controlled recovery/fork mechanism for exported host saves.

3. CREATE YOUR FIRST ROOM

Once you create the room, you enter the lobby.

You'll see your crawler listed with:

name, background, HP, Focus, connection state, and whether you're host.

You'll also see:

Copy Invitation

This copies the private invitation URL.

That's what you'd eventually send to another player.

Begin the Run

Only the host gets this.

With one player, just begin.

With multiple people, up to four crawlers can occupy the room.

Now start the game.

4. ORIENT YOURSELF BEFORE MOVING

The dungeon screen is divided into several functional areas.

The **large map** is the game world.

Across the top you'll see connection information, round number, and seed.

You'll also have:

Invite - copies your multiplayer invitation.

Settings - accessibility and presentation options.

Reconnect - normally disabled while you're successfully connected.

Export Save - available to the host.

Above the map are:

minus and plus - map zoom.

Inspect [F] - extremely important. We'll return to this repeatedly.

On the right is essentially your command center:

Floor Objective
Crew
Inspector
Transmission Log

And underneath the map is your action interface.

Before doing anything else, look at the tiny legend underneath the map:

? = objective

= boss device
+ = saferoom
> = descent

Those symbols matter more than they initially appear to.

5. EXPLORATION MODE

At the beginning you should see something like:

EXPLORATION - SERVER-CONFIRMED MOVEMENT

This means there is no immediate tactical threat.

Move with:

WASD or the **arrow keys**.

You can also click destinations.

Movement is orthogonal - north, south, east, west. There is no diagonal movement.

Ordinary floor movement costs **1 AP per tile** once you're in tactical combat. Difficult terrain changes that. Rubble costs an additional AP. Water normally costs an additional AP unless your build changes that.

But during safe exploration, you don't have to tediously plan three AP every few seconds. The server accepts short exploration actions immediately.

This is the game's hybrid structure:

safe situation = fluid dungeon exploration
danger = deliberate tactical rounds

6. FOG OF WAR AND VISION

The game remembers explored terrain.

Your normal sight radius is approximately **8 tiles**.

Dark areas can reduce that to **4** unless you have an appropriate light benefit.

Walls and thick smoke obstruct vision.

Your party shares explored terrain, but there's an important distinction between **having explored a location** and **currently seeing an enemy**.

That matters in multiplayer.

7. INSPECT EVERYTHING

Press **F**.

You're now in Inspect mode.

Click a tile.

The right-hand Inspector tells you what's actually there.

For ordinary terrain it can show:

terrain type, material tags, and cover.

For an enemy:

name, HP, tags, and telegraph information.

For machinery:

what the object is, whether it has already been completed, and its operation.

For hazards, it gets much more useful.

You'll see things such as:

FIRE - intensity X - duration - damage per tick

plus information about what the hazard does and how it propagates.

This is one of the most important systems in THE CRAWL because the dungeon isn't merely scenery.

The environment is part of the combat system.

We'll get into that properly in a moment.

Inspect mode costs no AP.

There is also **Ping Tile**, which becomes especially useful in multiplayer.

8. DOORS AND OBJECTS

Walk adjacent to an object and look at **Nearby Actions**.

Contextual buttons appear automatically.

Depending on the object you may see things like:

Loot
Enter
Use

Doors can be opened and closed.

Opening or closing a door normally costs **1 AP**.

Locked doors may have several possible solutions depending on the situation:

a key, lockpicking or hacking, or simply destroying appropriate structural material.

This is representative of a larger design principle in the game:

> **problems frequently have physical and technical solutions rather than one prescribed interaction.**

9. YOUR FIRST ENEMY CHANGES THE GAME

Eventually a hostile notices you or an active environmental threat begins.

The phase changes to:

> **TACTICAL PLANNING - 3 AP - TEAM COMMITS TOGETHER**

This is where THE CRAWL actually reveals itself.

Every living crawler gets:

> **3 Action Points per round**

and normally **1 reaction opportunity**.

Unused AP does **not** carry over.

Now your actions aren't immediately happening when you click them.

You're building an **Action Plan**.

10. THE ACTION BAR

The main buttons are:

Move [1]

Movement planning.

Click a tile and the game queues as much of the path as your available AP allows.

You can see the queued movement before committing.

Attack [2]

Select Attack, then click a valid enemy.

Basic attacks normally cost **2 AP**.

Light weapons can attack for **1 AP**, generally at a damage penalty.

Melee normally requires orthogonal adjacency.

Ranged weapons have their own ranges.

Guard [3]

Guard costs **1 AP**.

It gives you **+2 armor through the enemy phase**.

This is not merely "skip turn defensively." It's a proper defensive reaction state.

Dodge

Dodge imposes a **20-point accuracy penalty against the next relevant attack**.

Guard and Dodge therefore solve different defensive problems.

Overwatch

This prepares a reaction during enemy activity.

Reactions are bounded to prevent ridiculous recursive interrupt chains.

Inventory [I]

We'll spend considerable time here.

Character [C]

Character stats, statuses, talents, profession, adaptation.

Ability selector / Use Ability

Your general abilities and eventually profession abilities appear here.

The UI tells you:

AP cost, Focus cost, and range.

Undo

Removes the most recently queued command.

Ready [R]

> **This is the important one.**

Your queued actions are not executed until you're ready.

In multiplayer, every active crawler plans simultaneously. Once everybody presses Ready, the round resolves.

You can Unready and alter your plan before resolution.

11. WHAT "SIMULTANEOUS" ACTUALLY MEANS

Suppose you queue:

move north,

move north,

guard.

Your teammate queues:

move east,

attack.

Neither of you watches the other person execute first.

Instead the server takes everyone's accepted commands and resolves the tactical round deterministically.

Broadly, the order is:

statuses tick,

initiative is determined,

player movement resolves,

player non-movement actions resolve,

environmental reactions propagate,

enemies act,

end-of-round effects occur.

Initiative is based around:

> **10 + Finesse + speed modifiers + seeded d6.**

Ties are deterministic.

That means you can coordinate plans without one player effectively playing an entire turn while everybody else watches.

12. ENEMIES DON'T GET CHEAP SURPRISE ATTACKS

There's a deliberate fairness rule here.

If you discover a hostile during exploration, **it doesn't immediately sucker-punch you**.

The game enters Planning and gives you an opportunity to respond.

Boss attacks are even more explicit: their dangerous areas are telegraphed **one full round ahead**.

If you see **! tiles**, pay attention.

Those are not decoration.

The UI literally reminds you:

> **Boss attacks mark tiles one round ahead. Move out of ! tiles.**

13. ATTACK PREVIEW

Select Attack and inspect/select an enemy.

The preview can show:

AP cost,

maximum range,

actual distance,

whether line of sight is clear,

whether you're out of range,

and your calculated **hit percentage**.

That's valuable because THE CRAWL isn't hiding its basic combat math.

The base accuracy formula starts around **70%**, then considers Finesse, weapon accuracy, enemy status, cover, and range beyond the weapon's optimal distance.

Accuracy is ultimately bounded between **10% and 95%**.

Cover makes you harder to hit rather than acting as additional armor.

Critical chance is separate.

14. DAMAGE

Damage isn't simply "weapon says 8, enemy loses 8."

The game considers:

weapon base damage,

relevant attribute,

equipment modifiers,

a seeded d4,

critical multiplier,

armor,

and resistance.

Damage types include:

physical,

fire,

shock,

acid,

cold,

poison,

and psychic.

And those elemental types matter because they connect into the status and environmental systems.

15. STATUS EFFECTS

You'll see active statuses on the Character panel and beside crawlers.

Some of the important ones:

Burning - fire damage over time.

Poisoned - poison damage over time.

Bleeding - physical damage over time.

Corroded - armor reduced by 2.

Chilled - movement costs an additional AP.

Stunned - your next tactical budget falls from 3 AP to **2 AP**.

Confused - accuracy reduced by 15.

Exposed - incoming attacks gain 15 accuracy.

Aimed - your accuracy gains 15.

Normally applying the same status again refreshes duration rather than endlessly stacking potency.

16. NOW THE FUN PART: THE DUNGEON IS A WEAPON

This is probably the system I most want you to experiment with.

THE CRAWL simulates interactions between materials and elements.

For example:

Fire + flammable material

It burns and can spread.

Fire + oil

The burning can travel through connected oil.

Fire + gas

> **Explosion.**

Gas is consumed and produces a blast.

Shock + water

Electricity propagates through connected wet or conductive tiles.

This can turn an entire flooded area into a weapon.

Shock + metal enemy standing in water

Additional shock damage and stun.

Water + fire

Reduces the fire but creates temporary **steam**, which can obstruct vision.

Cold + water

Freezes it.

The resulting ice can become slippery.

Acid + metal

Corrodes armor or machinery.

Blast + brittle wall

Can actually destroy the wall and create a new route.

Force + hazard

Push an enemy into fire, electrified water, poison, a pit, etc.

Poison gas + fire

Certain combustible poison clouds flash-burn.

Water + powered machinery

Can short the machine - potentially creating electrical danger unless you've disabled the power first.

Damage + explosive barrel

The barrel primes and detonates on a subsequent resolution step.

So don't think:

> **"What attack does the most damage?"**

Think:

> **"What can I make this room do?"**

That is much closer to the intended high-level play.

17. FRIENDLY FIRE

Directly targeting another crawler with an ordinary attack is prohibited.

But environmental and explosive friendly fire **is absolutely real**.

If you throw an area effect onto a teammate, electrify the water they're standing in, detonate something beside them, or create another hazardous chain reaction, they can be hurt.

The interface attempts to warn you when an area action includes a crawler.

So when you get the confirmation:

> **This area may hit a crawler.**

believe it.

18. INVENTORY

Press **I**.

This is a real inventory system, not just a list of pickups.

At the top you'll see:

slots used / available
current weight / carrying capacity

and your current equipment.

Your baseline inventory is **10 slots**, modified by certain effects.

Weight capacity is based largely on Might:

10 + 3 x Might, plus other modifiers.

Every item card explains what it actually does.

Depending on the item you'll have buttons such as:

Equip

For weapons, armor, trinkets and appropriate tools.

Use / Target

For consumables, usable tools, and quest items.

Selecting this may close the inventory and ask you to choose a map target.

Drop at Cache

Removes the item into the world/cache system.

Give to [Crawler]

If another living crawler is adjacent, you can offer them the item.

They must consent.

The recipient gets Accept Trade or Decline.

That's deliberate - another player can't simply force junk into your inventory.

Materials that aren't directly usable are identified as **Recipe Material**.

19. EQUIPMENT

You have meaningful equipment slots including:

weapon,

armor,

trinkets,

offhand/tool-related equipment depending on item implementation.

Weapons show things such as:

damage,

damage type,

range,

accuracy,

and traits.

Armor provides actual armor and modifiers.

Trinkets tend toward passive modifications.

So when comparing equipment, don't judge solely from the item's name or nominal power. Look at the mechanics text Codex added to each card.

20. CHARACTER SCREEN

Press **C**.

This is where your build starts making sense.

You'll see:

name,

background,

level,

attributes,

derived modifiers,

profession,

adaptation,

and wounds.

The core attributes influence things such as HP, Focus, accuracy, skills, and various content-specific checks.

Your starting HP is fundamentally derived from:

20 + 4 x Might, with another **4 maximum HP per level**.

Focus is based substantially on Wit:

5 + 2 x Wit before modifiers.

Focus powers special abilities.

If you don't use a special ability during a round, you generally recover **1 Focus**.

21. LEVELING

XP belongs to the **team**, not individual kill-stealing players.

The progression thresholds are:

Level 1: 0

Level 2: 20

Level 3: 45

Level 4: 75

Level 5: 110

Level 6: 150

Level 7: 195

Level 8: 245

At level-up, living crawlers receive **three talent offers**.

The Character screen will display **Choose a Talent** when you have a pending offer.

Pick one.

Non-stackable talents can't simply be duplicated forever.

You also automatically gain maximum HP as you level.

22. FLOOR THREE CHANGES YOUR CHARACTER

This is important enough to remember now.

Starting in a saferoom on **Floor 3**, you make two major identity choices:

Profession

and

Adaptation.

There are **eight professions** and **six adaptations** implemented.

These aren't cosmetic labels. Codex wired them into executable modifiers and abilities.

Your Profession tends to define your functional specialization and available skill set.

Your Adaptation further alters how your crawler interacts with the game's rules, generally combining advantages and tradeoffs.

You choose each once for the run.

There is deliberately **no casual respec system**.

The Character screen lets you inspect all the available options before committing.

23. SKILL CHALLENGES

Some interactions aren't combat attacks at all.

The underlying system uses:

d20 + relevant attribute + skill rank

against difficulty classes.

Broadly:

10 = standard

14 = hard

18 = very hard

Natural 1 automatically fails.

Natural 20 automatically succeeds.

And the game deliberately prevents endlessly clicking the same failed skill check until RNG eventually gives you a 20.

Failure can change the object into states such as jammed, spent, or alerted.

24. YOUR FLOOR OBJECTIVE

Look at the upper-right **Floor Objective** panel.

This tells you the required objective and progress:

something like **0 / X complete**.

Underneath is the boss.

Then:

Alternative: X / X devices

This is crucial.

THE CRAWL's floors aren't intended to mean:

wander until boss -> reduce giant health bar to zero.

Each floor has its own objective structure and boss encounter.

And every boss has an **alternative device-based resolution**.

So broadly you have two philosophies:

fight the monster

or

understand the room and defeat the encounter systemically.

You can mix those approaches too.

25. BOSS DEVICES

Remember the map legend:

= boss device

These are the machinery involved in alternative boss resolution.

The alternative routes are ordered systems rather than one magic "skip boss" button.

So inspect them.

Read their operation.

Figure out what order or conditions the floor expects.

This is where hacking, quest materials, machinery manipulation, structural interactions, and environmental control can become as important as raw combat.

26. THE AUDIENCE

Now look at the number labeled:

Audience 0/100

This is another major system that isn't immediately obvious.

The game watches how you play.

Novel systemic kills can increase audience interest.

Elemental combinations can increase it.

Heroic rescues can increase it.

Repeating the same boring trick doesn't continue farming points.

Extended safe, uneventful play can gradually reduce it.

Important thresholds are around:

25
50
75

Increasing Audience doesn't simply make enemies stronger.

It opens **Producer offers** - optional risk/reward bargains.

The Director is effectively rewarding interesting behavior while offering you increasingly dangerous opportunities.

27. DOWNED DOES NOT MEAN DEAD

Eventually somebody is going to hit zero HP.

The first time, they become **DOWNED**.

They remain down for **three full round boundaries**.

They have no AP.

An adjacent ally can revive them for:

2 AP + a medkit

or through certain relevant abilities.

They return with approximately **20% maximum HP** and receive a **wound**.

But there is a serious consequence:

If they hit zero HP again **before the next rest**, they die.

If the downed countdown expires, they die.

And death is permanent for that run.

28. DEAD PLAYERS STILL PARTICIPATE

A dead crawler doesn't disappear from the multiplayer session.

They become a spectator.

They can:

watch surviving crawlers,

inspect,

and ping locations.

Their equipment can generally be recovered by teammates.

But they stop receiving normal progression and loot.

So death is serious without telling a human player, "Thanks for joining us, stare at a blank screen for an hour."

29. SAFEROOMS

Eventually you'll reach a **+**.

All living crawlers need to gather appropriately for progression.

Entering the saferoom changes the phase and unlocks **Saferoom Services**.

This screen is effectively the between-floor economy and progression hub.

There is a lot here.

Rest - once this floor

Rest restores:

35% maximum HP
all Focus

and clears most temporary statuses.

But it does **not** automatically remove wounds.

You only get one full rest per crawler per floor.

So you cannot grind infinite healing.

Treat Wound

The medic service removes a wound.

The current cost is:

5 x current floor credits.

So wounds become increasingly expensive to casually ignore.

Rewards & Overflow

Boss rewards use a draft system.

If it's your turn, you can **Claim** or **Pass Reward**.

Items that can't fit normally can end up in the saferoom overflow/chest rather than simply vanishing.

Shop

The shop has seeded inventory.

Prices rise with floor depth.

The base formula increases prices roughly **10% per floor after Floor 1**, with your own discount/tax modifiers applied.

Sell

Selling returns roughly **40% of nominal value**.

Recipes

Crafting consumes actual materials you've found.

There are **10 authored recipes** in this build.

Producer Offers

This is where Audience pays off.

You'll see an offer with its description and one or more choices.

And importantly, the UI explicitly tells you the **risk** associated with each choice.

These bargains are optional.

You don't have to accept the Producer's nonsense.

There are **25 authored bargains/events** represented in the implemented system.

30. DESCENDING

Completing the objective alone isn't enough.

You need to:

> **complete the required objective**

and

resolve the boss - either conventionally or through its alternative route.

Then descent becomes available.

In multiplayer this requires a **crew vote**.

You don't get to unilaterally drag three people onto the next floor because you clicked the staircase first.

31. THE SIX-FLOOR RUN

The game contains six procedurally assembled **45 x 45** floor layouts.

These aren't simply six random reskins.

Each floor has:

its own grammar,

required route,

optional routes,

objective,

boss,

boss alternative,

environmental opportunities,

and saferoom progression.

Codex tested **60,000 generated layouts** - 10,000 per floor - for required connectivity and safe spawning.

That doesn't guarantee every map is perfectly fun, but it does mean there is substantial automated work behind making sure the procedural generator doesn't casually create impossible mandatory routes.

32. OPTIONAL ROUTES

Some maintenance routes can be locked.

The mandatory path is supposed to remain physically achievable.

Optional routes may allow:

keys,

hacking,

or structural destruction.

This means that when you see an apparently inaccessible side area, don't automatically assume the procedural generator screwed up.

Inspect it.

There may be another way in.

And yes, **blowing through certain walls is genuinely supported**.

33. MOVEMENT COLLISIONS IN MULTIPLAYER

Here's a subtle expert-level mechanic.

If two crawlers attempt to enter the same cell during tactical resolution, initiative determines who successfully claims it.

The losing move becomes a wait and does **not** consume the AP.

Allied swaps are possible only under the explicit appropriate movement conditions.

Enemies and crawlers cannot simply swap through one another.

So coordinated movement becomes important in narrow corridors.

Codex's own automated campaign testing actually found a congestion problem around an exit during development. It wasn't a fake theoretical concern.

34. INVALID ACTIONS AREN'T SUPPOSED TO DESTROY YOUR TURN

Suppose you plan an attack, but resolution changes the world and the action becomes invalid.

The server validates:

AP,

target,

range,

visibility,

inventory,

phase,

and other conditions.

An invalid individual action becomes a WAIT for that action and reports why.

It doesn't silently redirect your attack to something else.

This is another reason to read the **Transmission Log**.

35. THE TRANSMISSION LOG

Don't ignore this panel.

It preserves recent events such as:

damage,

attacks,

misses,

abilities,

environmental effects,

and system messages.

If something happens and your immediate reaction is:

> **Wait, why the hell did I just take damage?**

look here.

The log will often tell you the source and damage type.

This becomes especially important during complicated environmental chain reactions.

36. THE ENVIRONMENT RESOLVES IN AN ORDER

For expert play, understand that elemental interactions aren't random chaos.

Environmental effects resolve in a deterministic priority roughly involving:

structural collapse,

liquid flow,

fire,

electricity,

acid,

cold,

poisonous gas,

smoke.

The simulation allows multiple propagation substeps but has hard caps preventing runaway infinite reaction loops.

That means you can eventually learn to **predict chain reactions**.

And that's where mastery starts becoming interesting.

37. PUSHING IS EXTREMELY VALUABLE

Forced movement can be better than raw damage.

Knockback can push something tile by tile until blocked.

If it collides, it can take collision damage.

If there's a valid pit, it can fall.

If there's fire, electrified water, acid, poison, or another hazard behind it, you've turned positioning into damage.

This is one reason the game rewards thinking spatially rather than just comparing DPS numbers.

38. FOCUS AND ABILITIES

Your ability dropdown shows skills available to you.

General skills can be available broadly; profession-specific abilities appear according to your build.

Each shows:

> **AP cost / Focus cost / range**

Select one and press **Use Ability**.

If it's self-targeting, the game may immediately queue it.

If it needs a target, you'll enter targeting mode.

The Inspector then gives you useful information about:

range,

LOS,

AP,

Focus,

area radius,

and ally danger.

Use this preview.

It is effectively your tactical calculator.

39. SETTINGS

Open Settings.

Codex implemented:

> **Standard / Large / Extra Large text**

and optional **Synthesized Action Sounds**.

Reduced motion is effectively enforced in this alpha: there is no camera shake, flickering, or animated attack spectacle.

That may eventually be something we want to revisit aesthetically, because the game is currently intentionally conservative about visual animation.

But mechanically that's what you're seeing.

40. HOST-SPECIFIC CONTROLS

If you're host, you have a few additional responsibilities.

Export Save

Creates a checksummed backup of the run.

Force Ready After 45s Idle

In multiplayer, if somebody genuinely stops responding during tactical planning, the host can eventually force the round onward.

This is deliberately not an instant "host overrides everyone" button.

Park Offline Crawler

If somebody has been disconnected for more than five minutes, the host can park that crawler near the saferoom under the appropriate circumstances.

A disconnect itself **never kills the character**.

After about 30 seconds offline during combat, the disconnected crawler defaults toward guarding behavior rather than becoming helpless.

41. THE FINAL FLOOR

Floor 6 culminates in the **Signal Engine**.

This isn't merely another boss HP bar.

The final uplink/objective unfolds across **three telegraphed stages**.

As elsewhere, the climax supports the game's combat/systemic philosophy.

Once the final condition is genuinely satisfied, the **server** - not the browser UI - marks victory.

That distinction matters because it prevents reconnecting or client weirdness from manufacturing a fake win.

42. THE END SCREEN

Victory or defeat produces a proper recap.

You'll see:

run seed,

floor reached,

number of turns,

duration,

Audience,

each crawler's fate,

level,

profession/background,

feats earned,

unlocks,

and the boss routes taken through the campaign.

You can **Copy Recap**.

Or begin a **New Run**.

Victories can unlock cosmetic palettes for future characters, but again:

> **there is no permanent stat treadmill.**

Knowledge is your primary metaprogression.

Which is appropriate for this kind of game.

43. WHAT I WANT YOU TO DO ON THIS FIRST PLAYTHROUGH

Don't try to win efficiently.

For this run, you're learning the machine.

So deliberately experiment.

Inspect machinery.

Shoot or damage something structural.

Try fire around flammable terrain.

Try water around electricity.

Freeze wet terrain.

Push something into a hazard.

Watch what happens when you manipulate doors.

Look at your hit percentage at different ranges and around cover.

Take an ability and inspect its targeting preview.

Open every inventory item and read its mechanical description.

Look at the Character panel every time you level.

Try an alternative boss device rather than automatically killing everything.

Pay attention to Audience when you do something unusual.

Visit every saferoom service.

Craft something.

Buy and sell something.

If you have another player later, test giving an item, simultaneous movement, revival, reward drafting, and coordinated planning.

> **Treat the first run as laboratory work.**

44. THE MENTAL MODEL THAT MAKES YOU GOOD AT THE GAME

A beginner sees:

> **my crawler + my weapon + the enemy.**

A competent player sees:

> **3 AP + positioning + accuracy + armor + statuses.**

An expert sees:

> **the entire room as a state machine.**

Where is the water?

What conducts?

What burns?

What explodes?

What blocks LOS?

Can that wall come down?

Can that enemy be moved?

Can machinery be disabled instead of fought?

What is the boss telegraphing?

What are my teammates planning?

Can I create a chain reaction?

Is the alternative boss route cheaper than winning a straight fight?

Is increasing Audience worth the additional risk?

Should we spend our credits now or preserve them for later floors?

Can we afford another wound?

> **That's THE CRAWL.**